

There is an old country saying that if you ever see a turtle sitting on a fencepost, you know it did not get there by itself. I am that turtle.

I was abandoned as a child and raised by my grandfather in rural northeast Mississippi. He was forty five years older than me and had only a third grade education, yet he possessed a deep belief in the power of learning. He often told me there were two forms of education: the academic kind found in classrooms, and the human kind gained through people, mentorship, and lived example. Both shaped me and ultimately set the trajectory for every milestone I would later reach.

My grandfather encouraged formal schooling not because he had experienced it himself, but because he hoped I might one day have opportunities that had been denied to him. At the same time, he introduced me to people in our community whom he believed could instill discipline, broaden my understanding of the world, and guide me toward a better future. Some would later become U.S. Senators, Governors, legislators, and business leaders, but to me they were early examples of what education and opportunity could make possible.

His belief in learning helped me become the first person in my family to graduate high school. I then attended a small community college before transferring to the University of Mississippi, working multiple jobs along the way to support myself. My undergraduate journey unfolded in two phases as life circumstances intervened. The path was far from traditional and filled with financial and personal challenges, yet I never wavered in my pursuit of a degree. Those experiences strengthened my resilience and reinforced my belief that education is not merely a means of escaping one's circumstances, but a way to honor those who believed in you.

When I graduated from the University of Mississippi, I became the first in my family to earn a college degree, fulfilling a dream my grandfather and I had shared since my earliest years. Later, I pursued an MBA at the Daniels College of Business at the University of Denver. By that time in my life I had reached a level of personal and financial stability that allowed me to fully dedicate myself to my studies. The experience proved transformative. I strengthened my abilities in research, quantitative reasoning, critical thinking, and structured problem solving while learning to analyze complex business challenges and communicate ideas with clarity and rigor. Most importantly, it demonstrated how education can reshape not only a career path but also the way one thinks and engages with the world.

Today, as a consultant working with technology firms, government stakeholders, and growth stage companies, I regularly encounter strategic and organizational challenges that raise deeper questions about leadership, decision making, and long term value creation. Many of these questions would benefit from the kind of disciplined inquiry and evidence based analysis that doctoral study provides.

For this reason, I am seeking to continue my academic journey through the Doctor of Business Administration program at the Kelley School of Business at Indiana University. The program's emphasis on producing scholar practitioners who translate rigorous research into meaningful business insight aligns closely with my professional path and future aspirations.

Professionally, I hope to deepen my research capabilities and develop frameworks that help organizations navigate complex strategic decisions with greater clarity. Personally, I aspire to teach and mentor future students while continuing to work at the intersection of research and practice. I am particularly motivated to encourage students from backgrounds like my own, those whose paths to higher education may not have been obvious or easy.

I approach the Kelley DBA with several developing research ideas drawn from my professional experience and a strong desire to refine them under faculty guidance. I look forward to engaging in the disciplined work required to transform those questions into meaningful contributions to both scholarship and practice.

For me, this pursuit represents more than an academic milestone. It is the continuation of a journey that began decades ago in rural Mississippi when a man with little formal education instilled in me a lifelong respect for learning. The Kelley School of Business offers an environment where that journey can continue, allowing me to contribute to the field of business while honoring the belief in education that first set me on this path.

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